

SECOND EDITION

PATHFINDER[®]

For D&D 5e Players



Welcome to Pathfinder 2nd Edition!

The Biggest Mindset Shift

PF2e and D&D 5e share a lot of fantasy DNA, but they *play* very differently at the table.

The Biggest Mindset Shift:

PF2e rewards teamwork, tactics, positioning, preparation, and using the right action at the right time.

This guide is designed to help experienced 5e players avoid common beginner mistakes and feel effective quickly.

The Biggest Differences

D&D 5e	Pathfinder 2e
Advantage/Disadvantage	Circumstance bonuses / penalties and conditions
Action + Bonus Action + Movement	3 Actions + 1 Reaction
Bounded accuracy	Tight math scaling
Builds mostly defined by class	Builds defined by feats and choices
Multiattack scales automatically	Every attack after the first gets penalties
HP attrition expected	Tactical combat expected
Individual heroics	Team synergy is king
Flexible rulings-first design	PF2e has explicit rules for most things

The Golden Rule

+1 Matters. A LOT.

In PF2e, a +1 bonus can:

- Increase hit chance
- Increase crit chance
- Prevent enemy crits
- Stack with ally support

Because critical hits happen when you exceed a DC by 10, every modifier matters.

EXAMPLE

- AC 20 enemy
- Roll total 20 = hit
- Roll total 30 = critical hit

That means:

- Flanking
- Frightened
- Buff spells
- Aid
- Debuffs

...all dramatically improve party performance.

Critical Hits & Failures

PF2e uses **Four Degrees of Success**. Spells especially use this system.

Result	Outcome
Critical Success	Amazing
Success	Good
Failure	Bad
Critical Failure	Very Bad

Critical Success

- Beat the DC by 10+
- Or a Natural 20 improves your result

Critical Failure

- Fail by 10+
- Or a Natural 1 worsens your result

This applies to:

- Attacks
- Saves
- Skills
- Spells
- EVERYTHING

This makes buffs and debuffs extremely important.

The 3-Action Economy

Every turn you gain:

- 3 Actions
- 1 Reaction

Most activities cost 1 action.

Common Actions

Action	Cost
Strike	1 Action
Stride (Move)	1 Action
Raise Shield	1 Action
Recall Knowledge	1 Action
Demoralize	1 Action
Interact (draw item/open door)	1 Action
Most Spells	2 Actions
Cast many spells	2 Actions
Some powerful abilities	2-3 Actions

PF2e Combat Is About

- Positioning
- Teamwork
- Action efficiency
- Creating openings
- Supporting allies

Not standing still and attacking repeatedly.

Teamwork Wins Fights

PF2e assumes strong teamwork between party members.

Powerful Teamwork Examples

1. Fighter Trips enemy
2. Rogue attacks Off-Guard target
3. Bard applies Frightened
4. Cleric buffs allies

Small bonuses stack into devastating advantages.

Conditions Matter More Than Damage

Conditions are extremely powerful.

Condition	Effect
Frightened	Penalty to most checks
Off-Guard	Lower AC
Slowed	Lose actions
Stunned	Lose actions and reactions
Sickened	Penalties and action tax
Grabbed	Restricted movement

Removing enemy actions is often stronger than raw damage.

Multiple Attack Penalty (MAP)

This is the #1 thing 5e players struggle with.

Attacking repeatedly becomes less accurate.

Attack Number	Penalty
First Attack	No penalty
Second Attack	-5
Third Attack	-10

NOTE: Agile Weapons reduce MAP to:

- -4
- -8

Your Third Attack Is Usually Weak

Instead of attacking again:

- Move
- Feint
- Raise Shield
- Recall Knowledge
- Demoralize
- Trip
- Shove
- Grapple
- Aid an ally
- Take cover

PF2e rewards tactical variety.

Movement Matters More

In 5e:

- Opportunity attacks discourage movement

In PF2e:

- Reactions are rarer
- Movement is more fluid
- Positioning matters constantly
- Repositioning is encouraged
- Standing still is dangerous

Good Habits

- Reposition often
- Flank enemies
- Use terrain
- Break line of sight
- Retreat when needed
- Protect allies

Casters vs Martials

PF2e balances casters differently than 5e.

Casters are powerful in PF2e, but their power is broader and more tactical than in many 5e builds.

CASTERS EXCEL AT

- Area damage
- Buffs
- Debuffs
- Battlefield control
- Utility
- Exploiting weaknesses

CASTERS ARE STRONGEST WHEN:

- Targeting weak saves
- Supporting allies
- Adapting to encounters
- Using Recall Knowledge

MARTIALS EXCEL AT

- Reliable single-target damage
- Frontline control
- Consistent pressure

Healing Works Differently

Out-of-combat healing is expected.

PF2e assumes the party usually starts fights near full HP.

MAIN SOURCES:

- Treat Wounds
- Battle Medicine
- Healing spells
- Focus spells

The Medicine skill is extremely valuable.

A party without healing support will struggle.

Death & Dying Is Dangerous

Going unconscious in PF2e is much more dangerous than in 5e.

WHEN YOU DROP TO 0 HP

- You gain the Dying condition
- Your initiative changes
- Recovery checks happen every turn

RECOVERY CHECKS

Result	Outcome
Critical Success	Reduce dying by 2
Success	Reduce dying by 1
Failure	Increase dying by 1
Critical Failure	Increase dying by 2

IMPORTANT DIFFERENCES FROM 5E

- Getting healed does NOT fully reset danger
- You gain Wounded
- If you go down again, you start closer to death

THE BIG LESSON

Going unconscious repeatedly is extremely dangerous.

Shields Are ACTUALLY Good

In PF2e:

- Raising a shield costs an action
- Shields give AC bonuses
- Some classes can Shield Block

A shield user can become dramatically tougher.

Hero Points Save Lives

HERO POINTS CAN:

- Reroll checks
- Prevent death

IMPORTANT

You can spend all Hero Points to:

- Avoid dying
- Stabilize immediately

Always remember your Hero Points.

Recall Knowledge Is Incredible

Use Recall Knowledge constantly.

Learn:

- Weak saves
- Weaknesses
- Resistances
- Special abilities

A smart party often outperforms a high-damage party.

Skills Matter In Combat

Unlike many 5e games, PF2e expects skill usage during combat.

Skill	Combat Use
Athletics	Trip, Grapple, Shove
Intimidation	Demoralize
Deception	Feint
Medicine	Battle Medicine
Arcana/Nature/etc	Recall Knowledge
Acrobatics	Tumble Through

Difficulty Is Different

PF2e encounters are generally:

- **More tactical**
- **More dangerous**
- **More mathematically balanced**

A Severe encounter can absolutely kill reckless parties.

- PF2e encounters are tightly balanced
- Boss monsters are dangerous
- Severe encounters can overwhelm parties

Sometimes the best move is:

- Retreating
- Regrouping
- Changing tactics
- Gathering information first

PF2e rewards preparation more than brute force.

Common Rookie Mistakes

BAD

- Standing still
- Attacking 3 times
- Ignoring positioning
- Ignoring conditions
- Splitting the party
- Not healing between fights
- Not supporting allies

GOOD

- Flanking
- Buffing allies
- Debuffing enemies
- Repositioning
- Using Recall Knowledge
- Tactical movement
- Helping allies crit
- Removing enemy actions

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Fast Turn Checklist

BEFORE YOUR TURN

- Who needs help?
- Which enemy is weakest?
- Can you create Off-Guard?
- Can you buff/debuff?

DURING YOUR TURN

- First attack is strongest
- Move intelligently
- Use skills
- Protect allies
- Don't waste actions

AFTER YOUR TURN

- Did you set up the next player?

Key Terminology Translation

D&D 5e	Pathfinder 2e
Advantage	Usually bonuses/conditions
Disadvantage	Usually penalties/conditions
Opportunity Attack	Reactive Strike
Short Rest	Not really a thing
Long Rest	Daily prep/reset
Inspiration	Hero Points
AC	AC
Saving Throw DC	Spell/Class DC
Sneak Attack	Sneak Attack (but easier to trigger)
Grappled	Grabbed
Bonus Action	Just another action

How Character Creation Works

Character building in PF2e is extremely customizable, but it works very differently from 5e.

PF2e rewards specialization.

Trying to be good at everything is weaker.

Characters usually excel by:

- Picking a role
- Supporting party synergy
- Building around strengths

Every Character Is Built From Multiple Layers.

At level 1, your character is shaped by:

Choice	What It Gives You
Ancestry	Species traits and ancestry feats
Background	Skills, boosts, story flavor
Class	Core abilities and combat role
Ability Boosts	Your main stats
Skill Choices	Proficiencies and utility
Feats	Specialized customization

Two characters of the same class can feel completely different.

Your class matters less than your feat choices.

Instead of most power coming directly from class levels, PF2e characters gain many choices over time.

You regularly gain:

- Class feats
- Skill feats
- Ancestry feats
- General feats

These choices define your playstyle.

Example: Two Fighters

Both are Fighters.

But one focuses on:

- Shield defense
- Protecting allies
- Battlefield control

While another focuses on:

- Two-handed weapons
- Critical hits
- Aggressive offense

Same class. Completely different gameplay.

Beginner Advice by Role

Frontliners

- Flank constantly
- Protect allies
- Use Athletics actions
- Move strategically
- Raise shields when possible

Rogues/Skill Characters

- Create Off-Guard opportunities
- Use skills constantly
- Exploit enemy weaknesses
- Avoid standing toe-to-toe

Casters

- Learn enemy saves
- Use buffs/debuffs
- Don't just spam damage
- Save top spells for big moments

Support Characters

- You are EXTREMELY valuable
- Buffs win fights
- Healing prevents crits
- Action economy manipulation is king

Subclasses Work Differently

PF2e subclasses are usually chosen at level 1 and often shape your core mechanics.

Examples

Class	Subclass Equivalent
Cleric	Doctrine
Wizard	Arcane School
Bard	Muse
Rogue	Racket
Barbarian	Instinct
Druid	Order

Unlike 5e:

- Your subclass usually does NOT lock all future choices
- You continue customizing through feats every few levels

Your Build Evolves Constantly

In 5e, many characters are mostly “finished” after choosing subclass.

In PF2e:

- You continue making meaningful choices throughout the entire campaign
- Feats constantly shape your abilities
- Characters evolve over time

Character progression stays interesting for much longer.

Important Mindset Shift

In 5e:

- Your subclass often defines your build

In PF2e:

- Your feat choices define your build

Your class provides the foundation.

Your feats determine:

- Combat style
- Specialization
- Utility
- Tactical role

Archetypes & Multiclassing

PF2e handles multiclassing VERY differently from 5e.

No Level Dipping

In 5e, characters often:

- Take 1–3 levels in another class
- Delay progression
- Create powerful combinations

PF2e avoids this system entirely.

Instead, PF2e uses Archetypes.

Archetypes

Archetypes let you gain abilities from:

- Other classes
- Organizations
- Combat styles
- Special training
- Magical traditions

Without sacrificing your main class progression.

Multiclass Archetypes

Want a Fighter with Wizard magic?

Take the:

- Wizard Archetype

Want a Rogue with Bard abilities?

Take the:

- Bard Archetype

You gain:

- Thematic abilities
- Extra options
- Expanded versatility

While still remaining primarily your original class.

Archetypes Usually Cost Feats

Instead of taking levels in another class, you spend:

- Class feat choices
- to gain archetype abilities.

This keeps characters:

- Balanced
- Focused
- Effective in their main role

ARCHETYPES ALLOW:

- Huge customization
- Strong thematic builds
- Hybrid concepts
- Interesting utility options

Without breaking the game's math.

Example Character Concepts

Concept	Possible Build
Holy Warrior	Fighter + Cleric Archetype
Arcane Assassin	Rogue + Wizard Archetype
Monster Hunter	Ranger + Alchemist Archetype
Battlefield Commander	Fighter + Marshal Archetype
Pirate Duelist	Swashbuckler + Gunslinger Archetype

Archetypes are one of PF2e's best systems.

Beginner Character Advice

For Your First PF2e Character

Try to:

- Focus on one main role
- Maximize your key ability score
- Avoid spreading stats too thin
- Choose feats that support your strengths

PF2e rewards specialization more than generalization.

Don't Worry About "Perfect Builds"

PF2e is tightly balanced.

Most characters are viable if:

- Your key stat is strong
- You cooperate with the party
- You understand your role

System mastery helps...

...but teamwork matters far more.

Beginner-Friendly Classes Easier Starting Classes

- Fighter
- Barbarian
- Ranger
- Champion

Moderate Complexity

- Rogue
- Bard
- Cleric
- Monk

Higher Complexity

- Wizard
- Witch
- Alchemist
- Oracle
- Summoner

Complex does NOT mean stronger.

It usually means:

- More decisions
- More resource management
- More tactical knowledge required



Beginner Resources

Archives of Nethys

Official PF2e rules database.
<https://2e.aonprd.com/>

Pathbuilder 2e

Excellent character builder.
<https://pathbuilder2e.com/>

Wanderer's Guide

Alternative character builder.
<https://wanderersguide.app/>

PF2easy

Fast searchable rules reference.
<https://pf2easy.com/>

Excellent Beginner Videos

How It's Played

Fantastic rules explanations.
<https://www.youtube.com/@HowItsPlayed>

KingOogaTonTon

Very beginner friendly.
<https://www.youtube.com/@KingOogaTonTon>

The Rules Lawyer

Excellent tactical and system deep dives.
<https://www.youtube.com/@TheRulesLawyerRPG>

Final Advice

PF2e may initially feel:

- More tactical
- More difficult
- More rules-heavy

That's normal.

Once it clicks, PF2e becomes:

- Deeply strategic
- Extremely rewarding
- Highly customizable
- Wonderfully cooperative

Eventually someone will crit because:

- The Bard frightened the enemy
- The Fighter flanked it
- The Cleric buffed everyone

That moment is pure Pathfinder.